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Bob Magnusson

Bob Magnusson was born in New York City on February 24, 1947 and grew up in San Diego surrounded by music. He first played French horn and took up the bass in 1967, joining the Buddy Rich band a year later. Bob has recorded and performed with a long list of major artists including Sarah Vaughn, Art Pepper, Linda Ronstadt and Roger Kellaway. He lives in San Diego where he often performs with flautist Holly Hofmann and pianist Mike Wofford.

Bob was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 14, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Los Angeles filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Bob Magnusson with me, after a burning set at the International Jazz Party. I have a feeling when you work with Roger it's always an adventure.

BM: Always.

MR: Roger Kellaway — I should tell my film audience.

BM: Yeah I love working with Roger Kellaway and John Guerin. We've been trying to do something as a trio. It's kind of hard to get anybody to — we've made a CD but we haven't been able to get anybody to buy it. Roger does — he's such a versatile musician. He's done film writing and composed concertos for orchestras, and you name it and he's done it. And he has this terrific spirit of adventure when he plays, like you were bringing out. And so I really have to pay attention. It can go any place at any time with Roger.

MR: There's no coasting.

BM: Yeah. And it does, so I have to really stay awake.

MR: You know you mentioned something that I've been hearing lately and that is that it's hard to have a cohesive group of musicians that you can get an ensemble sound and some rehearsed stuff. That's a real shame.

BM: It is. And it's happened more in the last ten, fifteen years, that I guess the cost of flying has gotten more and more expensive. Because there are several people that I work with that say well we'd love to take the group, but then end up having to go themselves and then pick up musicians. They get very fine musicians generally, but there is still something different when you're just thrust together with somebody, as to when you get to work and play together some and get a real group ensemble sound happening. But it just seems to be kind of a problem nowadays. It's rare to see somebody take a whole quartet or quintet and travel with them.

MR: Now you started out on the French horn? Is that correct?

BM: Yes I did. Both my parents were classical musicians. My dad was a Juilliard graduate, studied clarinet, and I grew up in San Diego. I was born in New York City while he was attending Juilliard. I came to San Diego — I'm almost a native — at probably age three or something like that, and studied the horn for twelve years. Wanted to play in an orchestra like my dad, that was my ambition. Loved the classical guitar. Somehow I got this great interest in classical guitar. My dad took me to hear Segovia. I just flipped out as a kid. So he let me take classical guitar lessons as a sort of fun sideline thing, while still studying the horn, and playing in youth orchestras. And I have a brother four years older who had studied clarinet with my dad. And he got into a local rock band in San Diego. We lived by the beach, kind of beach-surf rock & roll. And they needed an electric bass player. So he says, "Well my kid brother, he'll do it, he plays the guitar." So he says to me, "It's the same as your guitar, the bottom four strings an octave lower." So that's how I started playing bass. It was electric bass, playing in rock bands. And then, just kind of a fun thing—

MR: Beach Boys stuff and all that?

BM: Yeah. Beach Boys and Dick Dale and the Daletones. Some really awful music for the most part. But I was having a lot of fun and making some money on the weekends playing dances. And then this band leader of a very good rhythm & blues band in San Diego, George Semper was his name, somehow he asked me join his band, which was miles above my abilities. And I loved it. And they seemed to think I was going to do okay, and I started, because it was very syncopated and I'd been playing this very straight up and down kind of music. And they were playing Bobby Blue Bland and Ike and Tina Turner and James Brown music. And it was wonderful. And then they were the ones that really kind of turned me on to some jazz. I was listening first to Jimmy Smith and some kind of r & b-ish jazz. Good, funky jazz. And somebody gave me the "Kind of Blue" record by Miles Davis. And that was it. It just sort of blew my mind. And I was 19, and I said that's it, and I wanted to play jazz. And I thought about guitar, I thought about the bass and I thought about the French — I mean I listened to some French horn players, and I didn't care for the French horn in jazz. I like it in arrangements but I don't like it as a solo.

MR: Yeah, there was very few guys.

BM: John Graas, maybe if you remember he was playing. And Dwight Mitchell.

MR: Right. What was it, Willie Ruff?

BM: Ruff and Mitchell-Ruff. I listened to some of those to get an idea. It's almost too regal of an instrument or something. And I thought about trumpet. Anyways I gravitated to the

bass, just being naive and thinking that it was like the electric bass. Little did I know. And so that was it. And I've never looked back.

MR: What was your father's opinion of you moving away from the classical?

BM: Both my mother and father thought, you know how kids grow up and you get into this fad or phase, and then you move over here. So they were very wise and didn't say much to me, but they told me later they thought to themselves well Bob's on another phase. And what actually happened was I'd been playing probably about a year or something. I practiced tons. I was practically a recluse. I worked in a cabinet shop days and I would just come home and practice the bass. All hours of the night and all weekends and play. The conductor of the San Diego Symphony heard me playing on a jazz program, it was "The Joe Masters Jazz Mass" if you're familiar with that, it's got some singing of jazz on some. And I played some arco parts you know. And he sent the guy up to me after the concert and hired me for the orchestra. Would I like to play in the symphony. So I says I'd love it. So I was the last bass. Eight bass players, last one on the line. And that's when my parents, when I told them they just like flipped out you know.

MR: This was the San Diego Symphony?

BM: The San Diego Symphony.

MR: And this was the one your father was in too?

BM: He had sort of semi-retired. But we did get to play a little together in the orchestra.

MR: That's wild.

BM: Yeah, it was a wild story. And then later — I did that for a season and then I moved to Las Vegas. I had met some guys. Played a couple of show bands. And through there I got the Buddy Rich band job.

MR: Were you playing electric at the same time?

BM: Yes. At that point I was playing both.

MR: And within a year — let's see if I'm doing this math right.

BM: Yeah.

MR: You started bass when you were 20?

BM: 19.

MR: And within a year or so you were working with Buddy Rich?

BM: Well probably about two years, yeah. It was way over my head, again way over my head. I mean I'd been just very kind of blessed to be in the right place at the right time or something. And I had heard of Buddy Rich but I didn't know, I was just this naive kid. Yeah, I want to play with Buddy Rich. So little did I know. And he didn't say a word for about four nights maybe. And I could read anything they had in the book. I could read anything. Didn't know any songs. Didn't know much about anything. But I could read,

whatever they put. Because I had read music all my life. And so after about three or four nights all of a sudden Buddy starts yelling at me, and cursing, while we're playing up on the stand in front of all these people. And I would get more and more frightened. And the more he'd yell, the worse I played. I just was like — and finally I was at my wit's end. We were in Copenhagen. Joe Azarello who you mentioned, was still on the band. And I went in. I was just a wreck. And I says, "Buddy, thanks, I'm just not making it." And I was trying to kind of give my notice. You know, "You'd be better off with somebody much more experienced than I am." And he came up and put his arm on my shoulder and he says, "That's all right kid, any time you want to play in this band you call me." It was like — what? He's been yelling at me every night. Cursing. And I couldn't understand. Then I sort of kind of relaxed at that point, because I'd given notice, and I wasn't caring as much. So I kind of relaxed and I started to do a better job, and I never left. I stayed a year playing with the band. And he never said you gave your notice, you better get out of here. So it was, I mean he was good to me, and it was a love/hate thing for me kind of with him. And he taught me a lot. He made me aware, really aware, of the importance of playing good solid time. Up to that point I was having a good time, but I don't think I was playing any good time.

MR: There you go. That's good advice right there. Make sure you're playing it if you're having it.

BM: So I look back at him with some love and some hate too.

MR: And I'm sure you're not the first person to say that either.

BM: But he did teach me some really good — and I met all kinds of great people: The LaBarbara's, Joe and Pat LaBarbara and Don Menza and Joe Romano and Art Pepper was on the band and Al Porcino, I roomed with Al Porcino.

MR: Which albums—

BM: Did I play? I only did one record it was kind of an awful record, it was called "Buddy and Soul." It was sort of Buddy's attempt at rock & roll. I think most of the tracks I ended up playing electric bass. On two or three I played string bass. But it was my first sort of big kind of project to get to do.

MR: Well that band certainly was a big hit with the college musicians too. I mean I remember listening to and wearing those records out with my roommates. And then getting the charts and trying to play them.

BM: Yeah he has some great bands and he was a real, you know he ran it like the military, like a Marine or something. He was a real taskmaster. But he demanded that it be tight and really sound good. I remember once he got us aside and he was really mad and yelling at us all. And he called us all kinds of names. "You just play loud and I'll do the shading,"

that's what he told us. I'll never forget that as long as I live. I thought how can we just play loud and he does the shading? But it was great.

MR: So you returned to San Diego. Was that always your home base after Vegas? Or did you move around some?

BM: Let's see. No I went back to Las Vegas at that point, had a little jazz gig in town, like an after-hours thing, it started at one or two in the morning and went until five or something. And I was playing the "Viva Le Girls" show before that. So I was playing my regular, it was in the lounge at the old Dunes Hotel, and then I'd run down and play this jazz gig all night. And Gus Mancuso, who is a wonderful musician who has lived in Vegas for many years, plays all kinds of instruments, one of those guys, recommended me to Sarah Vaughan, and I was scared to death. It was Jimmy Cobb playing drums, who was the drummer on the record. He was one of my heroes. I was so nervous. And Jan Hammer was the pianist at the time when I joined.

MR: This was '71?

BM: '72 or 1, around in there.

MR: Well I'm just trying to think of how that fits in with the Mahavishnu Orchestra.

BM: Well he left from Sarah probably after I had been there four or five months, and went right to the Mahavishnu Orchestra. And then we had Jimmy Rowles for kind of a hot minute, and then Bill Mays in New York. He was living out here at that time in L.A. He came on just for a brief time, and then Carl Schroeder had just left Roy Haynes' band. And Carl stayed many years, eight or nine years with Sarah. So that was most of the trio I worked with was Jimmy Cobb and Carl. He was there the whole time I was there. But it was one of the great experiences musically in my life to get to work with her. I would like to do it now. I might do her some justice. And again it was the same thing, I was in way over my head. She seemed to like me and think I had some potential and she was going to give me time to nurture it and bring it along. But it was an absolutely wonderful experience.

MR: Wow. You had said previously that you didn't know any tunes, like when you went with Buddy.

BM: Yeah.

MR: Had you worked up your repertoire some?

BM: By the time I worked with Sarah?

MR: Yeah.

BM: Yeah I was starting. I mean I've never been what I call a tunesmith, but I was trying to learn tunes and build up repertoire. And like playing that jazz gig after hours. And if I didn't have a jazz gig I would be out at a guy's house, some guys, Joe Morello, he's also

an Upstate, from Niagara Falls, he and Tony Morello. They were friends I had there. We would play any hour. Sometimes it was just him and I, tenor sax and bass we would play. Well here's how this tune goes. Because it's such a learning — I mean still at this point I'm still learning stuff. It's a lifelong learning venture, as you know being a musician yourself. So I was trying to build some repertoire and learn some things.

MR: Was Sarah a nice boss?

BM: She was a wonderful boss. You know she had the nickname "Sassy" and she could be, and I saw her do it in the three years that I worked for her. But never, ever with any of us musicians. With club owners that would try to give her a hard time, or management, that kind of thing. I would see her go off on them. But she loved the musicians. And she did some absolutely wonderful things. My wife Janet and I had our son at that time. We have a son and three daughters, and at the time we just had our — and we were in New York, we'd just finished working at the Rainbow Grill and I think we'd been there two or three weeks, and we had about three or four days off, and then we were going to the Fairmont Hotel in Dallas to work for another two or three weeks. And Sarah one night, we were hanging out and she says, "Are you going to hang in New York with Jan" or with some friends I had. I said, "No, I'm going home to see my wife and son." And she wasn't obligated for that short of a time to fly me anywhere but from New York to Dallas and then after that home. Marshall Fisher, who she was living with, she said, "Marshall, get Bob a ticket to San Diego." So she bought my ticket from New York back and she says, "Get yourself to Dallas." So by the time I did all the flying I had about a day and a half to see the family. I get back to Dallas, and Sarah says, "Did you have a good time?" I said, "Yeah, just too short, I miss Janet." And she says, "Would you like her and Matthew to come to Dallas?" I says, "I would love it." She says, "Marshall, buy Matthew and Janet plane tickets." She bought round trip, out of her pocket. She did wonderful — she wanted me to come to L.A., we had no savings, and this was in '75 when I rejoined. I had a son and a daughter now and my wife was pregnant with our second daughter, the third child. And Sarah had called me to see if I wanted to rejoin. I said, "Yeah I really would." It was right at a good time that I really wanted to come back. And she loaned us the money up front to get us up to L.A., and paid first and last rent and all that. I mean I have nothing but love and compassion — I'm beating up the microphone— a real special place in my heart for her. And then her singing was amazing. I mean she was great every night and then fantastic on other nights. I mean the consistency level was just amazing to me. And Jimmy Cobb also. Like between the two of them it was like going to graduate school or something for me, and I approached it like that. I says I realized I was lucky enough to be there with these people, take advantage of it, learn as much as you can. I thought if I can

get my groove with him, it'll be in the right place. And he was just a sweetheart to me. I mean he is just a lovely, lovely man. I love him dearly to this day.

MR: From Buddy Rich to Jimmy Cobb.

BM: Yep. Opposite ends of the spectrum you know.

MR: That's terrific.

BM: Two of the great drummers.

MR: You seem to be the guy on call in San Diego for the jazz films they do.

BM: Yes. Those Club Dates, on PBS. I'm actually doing one next Saturday with Bucky Pizzarelli. I'm doing one with Bucky so that will be fun. Yeah, it's been a real nice series. We actually had a jazz club back some years ago called Laurio's. And they brought in Hank Jones and Kenny Barron and Benny Golson and Kenny Burrell and on and on and on. And I was working with almost all of them. A lot of them I knew and had worked with before, some of the people, Art Pepper and some of the guys I had worked with at other times when I lived in L.A. I was in L.A. from '75 to '83. And then at that point went back to San Diego, to have a nice place for my family. That was our impetus to go there. We wanted a good family environment, and L.A. wasn't the place. I had four kids at that point and I thought, well I've gotten to do my thing now I'd better do something for these people. And it's been a good thing. And it's a small jazz community but there's some wonderful musicians living and playing there, and I've been very happy living, and about 90 percent of what I do is jazz playing so I feel pretty lucky.

MR: Were your kids aware of what you did for a living, and did they think it was out of the ordinary?

BM: No I don't think so. And my wife, she was always, and is, very, you know, the trash has to go out and the bed isn't made here and the kids need this. So it kept me in the real dad thing, which I'm really grateful for to her. I know with my mother and dad, my dad, playing in an orchestra is a huge amount of pressure. Principal clarinetist. And she kind of was very protective of him from us. You know, "Oh now don't upset your dad, he's got to play tonight." And some of that is good and there's times when yeah you appreciate it, but it also, I mean my dad and I talked as adults and he says if I had it to do over with I'd have spent more time making contact with you. So I'm a real homebody and a real family guy, and now we have two little grandsons, and I'm just having a ball. It gets to be more and more fun. I have two girls still at home, but both of my oldest daughter and son are married and they each have a little boy.

MR: Cool. Yeah, mentioning being a principal anything in a symphony, that's such a totally different kind of pressure, like every note has to be — the idea of mistake is so small.

BM: Yeah, we can make a mistake in jazz and move it into something. But they don't have that luxury there. It's a different kind of pressure. And I've done some orchestra playing on the French horn and on the double bass, and grew up around it, and my dad was marvelous at it, I mean he really did a wonderful job and exposed me to all kinds of great music, Shostakovich and all the traditional — Mozart and Brahms. And then I heard all the woodwind quintet literature, they would rehearse in our house. I remember going to sleep at night and they'd be upstairs and I'd hear the woodwind quintet when I was kid. Faure and just Pafanel, and all kinds of wonderful composers. So it was a great upbringing.

MR: Of the recordings you've done, are there any that stick out in your mind as being your best work?

BM: Yeah it always seems like as you do more recent stuff that always seems better because you keep evolving and growing. We just recently did a record for Fresh Sound which is from Barcelona I think, with Bud Shank. It's Mike Wofford playing piano and Joe LaBarbara, myself and Bud. And we did all music associated with Bill Evans. And it was really a fun project. I was happy with that. It was one of those dates we went in the studio and it just felt like we were playing live someplace, which is kind of hard to get and rare but it does happen on some occasions. And the sound was good and the music went good. So that was a lot of fun. And I just did some duo things with Sue Raney, also for this same label. It was Dick Shreve, piano and myself. A lot of it was just solo with Dick and Sue together, and then they put bass on maybe six or seven tracks. That I really enjoyed. So it always seems like the more recent stuff I get to do is better because I'm playing at another place. And when I heard old stuff I kind of cringe.

MR: Do your kids listen to your music?

BM: They do now. They're all adult. My youngest daughter will be 18 in March. So they're young adults. And they've really come to enjoy music and they like jazz, which I'm amazed, and they have tastes of things that they like. None of them are listening to heavy metal thank goodness. But they're listening to — and they've turned me on to some people — oh what's this girl's name — Sarah McLaughlin. I like her very much. Some people — I like a lot of r & b and some good pop and I'm not a jazz snob, I mean I have stuff I like. So they've turned me on to some really nice stuff. I'll hear something and say what is that, and they say oh it's so-and-so.

MR: When they brought their friends home from junior high school, I mean you didn't sit them down and say, here's my latest album.

BM: No, no, no, no.

MR: You don't score any points that way.

BM: Yeah.

MR: I see you also played with John Klemmer.

BM: Yeah.

MR: What happened to John Klemmer? I haven't—

BM: You know I saw Oscar Castro-Neves just Friday night, because we hadn't seen each other in quite a while and we worked together on that, and I was asking him, because I heard a new record on the radio of Oscar and John together. This was just like six months ago. So I asked Oscar I says, "Did you just do a—" he said, "No, that's from twenty years ago" he said, but somebody, JVC or somebody just put it out. So he hasn't seen — he says once in a while John calls him or something. He's kind of a recluse. I think he's still living in L.A. But none of the guys that I see that we worked together with him ever see him, so I don't know what's happening. He certainly was big there for a while.

MR: Yeah. He was doing the Echoplex and all that stuff.

BM: Yeah, I mean he was the Kenny G before Kenny G.

MR: And Joe Farrell, it's a great list of — what a great player he was.

BM: Yeah I loved Joe. And it was Victor Feldman and John Guerin did it also, on drums, we played a quartet. And then — who else? Oh Russell Ferrante did it some, from the Yellowjackets? Russell? He played piano with us some. And Peter Erskine did it also with us. And it was great fun. We did a few little tours and I got to do some recording with Joe and the first record I made as a leader I asked Joe would he participate, and he was kind enough to agree to do it. Yeah I loved him. He just was a sweet guy, a dear guy.

MR: Really. What was this Road Work Ahead?

BM: Road Work Ahead that's a funny story because the record I just mentioned that I did with Joe Farrell, I had Bill Mays, who I had been friends with for years, knew him from San Diego, played piano, John Guerin played drums. I played with a wonderful drummer and percussionist in San Diego, Jim Plank, he played percussion on it. And Albert Marks, if you remember Albert Marks, he had Discovery Records and Trend Records. He was the producer of this record I did. Well the record came out and they were playing it on the local jazz station here in L.A. and there was a club called Donte's, Cary Leverett was the owner at that time, and Cary phoned me and I used to work there a lot with Frank Rosolino and Joe Diorio and all kinds of different people. And Cary called me and says, "Hey Bob, I want — your record is getting played, I want you to bring your group in here." I says, "I don't have a group." He says, "Well what about your record?" I says, "Well I'll call some of those guys." And he sort of — "I'll put you in here for a weekend." So that's how this band came about. So I got Bill and Peter Sprague — are you familiar with Peter Sprague? He's a wonderful guitarist from San Diego, played with

Charles MacPherson and a lot of different, great people. Peter was in San Diego, and Jim Plank. So we put that group together. And we called it the Bob Magnusson Quartet and we started playing. And we were all having such a great time together with the group, and everybody was kind of writing and contributing music, and Bill was making arrangement. Bill is a prolific writer and wonderful, and Peter is too. And Peter would get us jobs in San Diego and we'd call it the Peter Sprague Quartet, and Bill would get a job and we'd call it the Bill Mays — Finally we got together and had dinner or something, and we says let's put a collective thing, and somehow we picked that from the sign — we says well we can get Cal Trans to give us free advertising if we use the name Road Work Ahead. So that's how the name came about. And one of the records I did as leader was the Bob Magnusson Quartet, "Road Work Ahead" was the name of the record, and they took a picture of me sitting by a Cal Trans sign. So we decided well let's use that. So then we did a group record called Road Work Ahead and we worked a lot under that. And I think it lasted two or three years, something like that, and we were having a ball. And then Bill decided to move to New York. And we thought about getting another pianist, but somehow it was the combination of the four guys that made the group what it was for us. So Peter and I played a lot, and Jim and I play a lot in different contexts, but we never did that particular thing. And once in a while Bill will come out from New York and we'll get a gig somewhere and put it together and play as a quartet, a Road Work Ahead reunion. So it's great fun once in a while, but it had such a special place to all of us. We thought it just won't be the same without Bill.

MR: Have you ever had to work a non-music job?

BM: Yeah I did, as a young person I worked in a cabinet shop like I think I mentioned earlier. I was an apprentice to the furniture finishers, which is mostly hand sanding, I did tons of that, some stripping. I got to do very little finishing. And I had odd jobs as a kid, I sold shoes in a store and I worked in a music store selling guitar picks and all that kind of stuff. I never really enjoyed much of any of that kind of thing. And so once I got a job playing music at age, about 20 I got my first little job, and I've just played ever since. I've just been playing and teaching. I enjoy teaching. I don't do a lot of it but I've always done some of it. I taught for almost 20 years at the BIT — Bass Institute of Technology in L.A. and I left that about two or three years ago. And I teach at a community college in San Diego two days a week I do a one and a half hour class. It's a combo class, where the kids play, and I coach them and help. And then I have three students through the college and I have two or three kind of high school kids that are really good, serious string bass players. And that's my teaching. A few hours a week.

MR: Send them up to Central New York. We could use some good acoustic players.

BM: Yeah, these kids are into it, and it's really inspiring to me, you know it gets me like going, oh man, because their enthusiasm is so great, for the music. And to see young people like that serious about the music. They're carrying the torch these guys. And you always hear jazz is dead and this and that, and it's always going to be a select and an elite audience, but just like classical music, but it's not going to ever die. And just seeing these people confirms that even more in my mind. It's really great.

MR: Do you see any, in your area or in Los Angeles, is there any kind of racial dividing happening in the jazz world that you witness?

BM: I don't see it in San Diego. We have black and white guys playing around town and a lot of groups where we're together and others where we're not. But I don't ever get — you know sometimes you get vibes about that from somebody. But I don't sense that around there. It's been so long since I've been in L.A., since '83, I never noticed it much around L.A. I don't know if it is now more or less.

MR: No, there seems to be a lot of press about — books about, what about the white guys' contribution to jazz these days, and there's some stuff floating around, and I just wondered if it got down—

BM: No I don't see it. I mean I've read stuff like that, and I feel there's bitter people in any kind of race, any place on the planet. And if that's what they want to do, great. I mean you certainly can't take away from what black artists have done, and they certainly have been leaders, I mean Coltrane and Charlie Parker and Louis Armstrong. You know, but then we've had Bill Evans and I mean music is music and art is art, and it's personal preference to me. I have people I love that are black and white and yellow and green and purple and if they're wonderful players and if they're great people that makes it really special for me. And that's how I look at it all.

MR: San Diego is quite the ethnic — a variety of ethnic—

BM: Yeah we're a border town, we're right there on the edge, 15 miles away from the Mexican border, so we have large Hispanic, large black community. We're getting a big Asian community.

MR: Do you ever feel compelled to try to learn music that's coming into the area from those populations?

BM: Well I've always liked Latin music. I don't know, if you said oh that's a merengue or, I don't know all the technical terms. And I've even played with some Latin guys, in more kind of a jazz-Latin sort of context, and I'll say that to some of them and they says — just play how you feel and stuff. And I've of course picked up some of the sense of it and I got to tour South America a couple of times with Sarah which was a great experience. Argentina and Brazil and all over South America. And so I got to hear a lot of it live,

some of the real authentic music, the tango in Argentina, and the bass players play with the bow down there. Marvelous. I mean, and burning, swinging stuff. So that's always been a music that I've loved. And maybe sometime I'll have the time to really learn more about it.

MR: Some of that stuff is really odd. I mean the bass never seems to fall—

BM: Right, yeah. They play on the ands of two and the downs of four. They're not playing on the ones and threes like most of our Western music is. So it's really interesting music. And I've learned to feel some of it from that place. And I like it very much.

MR: What's in the near future for you? Playing with your grandchildren?

BM: Yeah, doing that a lot. I'm lucky enough to have a steady weekend jazz job, Holly Hoffman, who is a wonderful flute player, lives in San Diego, and Mike Wofford the pianist, and then Jim Plank had been doing it and he's been — we got our symphony back. I don't know if you heard our symphony went belly up.

MR: Oh, great news.

BM: It's back functioning, it just started this last year, so he's been very busy with that and he does the opera. So we've had another drummer, a wonderful drummer, Duncan Moore, and we have this quartet jazz job where we get to play jazz. It's at a Sheraton hotel on Harbor Island in San Diego. So I have a steady Friday and Saturday, and then I do, there's nice little winery which opened in Carlsbad, which is the north county, and we have trio kind of things there, without drums for the most part so I work there with Holly and Peter Sprague, the guitarist I mentioned, I work with him and Mundell Lowe once in a while will do it. He's living in San Diego. So different little things like that, playing around and I'm going to do Bud Shank's jazz camp in July this summer, go up and do that. That should be a lot of fun, I'm looking forward to that. It's in Port Townsend, up above Seattle, does that. Bobby Shew's coming to town in March, so I'm going to play with Bobby. We're old, old dear friends. I did a lot of recording, played in his group. And we go way back to Las Vegas days. I'm really looking forward to seeing Bobby, and just kind of various stuff like that, whatever I can get, with the teaching and playing around.

MR: Are you a writer at all? A composer?

BM: Most of the writing I've done is when they put the gun up to my head. When I have projects to do I would write some tunes for those kinds of things. Oh I actually got, there's a record company called Azica records that Holly's been recording for and they're talking to me about possibly doing a record, which I'm hoping would happen, I would like to do one. I didn't for a long time want to do one as a leader, and I really want to use Joey Baron, I don't know if you know Joey from New York?

MR: A piano player?

MB: No, Kenny Barron is the piano player, and I want to use Kenny too. I want to use Kenny. I haven't called Kenny about it, but I talked to Joey a little bit about it, and he's interested. And Peter Sprague, this guitar player I think and do a quartet thing. So that looks like it might happen. Hal Leonard is publishing a bass book that I've put together. I just got the drafts back from them a couple of weeks ago so I'm looking that over. So that will be coming out — it's a "How To Build Walking Bass Lines" kind of thing. Just what the world needs, another waking bass line. But it was fun. I kind of came up with some angles I thought that were kind of my own over the 30 some years of playing. At first I thought why do it, but there is some validity to it I think.

MR: Well I was supposed to ask you a question about your bass. There's something different about the neck or something?

MB: I don't know other than it's a very long length.

MR: I think that's what it was.

MB: Most guys play what's called a three quarters, the standard sized bass. And the string length from the neck to the bridge is usually 41-1/2" to 42 inches, right in there. My bass runs 43-1/2" so you're dealing with another inch, so you have to of course spread everything wider and wider and bigger. So I rarely sit in on other guys basses, I'm so used to this great big thing, and everything would be all out of tune.

MR: And consequently if they tried to play yours it would be pretty nasty too.

BM: Yeah, it's a little bit. So maybe that might be what somebody had mentioned.

MR: Right. I'm constantly amazed at what those string instruments go for these days.

BM: Yeah they're completely appreciating all the time. I bought my bass 32 years ago for $475. And I think it was like ten years ago I had it appraised and they appraised it at $15,000 then. And lots of people are buying them as investments, that aren't musicians, or might just have an interest in buying instruments and keeping them for some time and selling them for a lot more.

MR: Well listen, I want to thank you for coming up after your gig.

BM: Well it's my pleasure to talk to you.

MR: I'll look forward to maybe getting down to San Diego, which seems to be a really nice town.

BM: It's a great place to live, I mean I'm prejudiced but I love living there, and I'm an ocean person, I do some surfing and I play tennis, so it's a great place to be for those activities.

MR: All right. Well thanks for your time.

BM: My pleasure, thank you.